

CPPA 122 – Local Government and Politics

Assignment #2 – Municipal Issues

This assignment gives you an opportunity to focus on a key municipal issue. Choose one of the following topics for your paper:

- **Power and Politics** - Political leadership can be difficult in a municipal system where decisions get made by a Council and the Mayor has few formal powers. Some advocates argue that large Canadian municipalities (cities) need a strong mayor system. Ontario has extended some additional powers to mayors of many municipalities in the province; other provinces have not. There is a range of opinion on the question of how power should be distributed among councillors and mayors in Canadian municipalities. What is your position on the issue of strong mayor powers? Do you agree or disagree? Why or why not? Your paper should include a description of strong and weak mayor systems as well as the current system in your municipality. Use evidence from your research to support your discussion and your position on the assignment of strong vs weak mayor. (**Note:** this is not a discussion on the strong mayor powers given to some municipalities in Ontario, although this may be part of your analysis – it is a broader discussion of the distribution of power at the local level).
- **Municipal Policy** - Are municipalities policy makers or policy takers? Describe/define both terms (policy makers and policy takers) and discuss/explain your position on the question, using examples from your research on a municipal issue such as the environment, housing, or a different that you are interested in. Reflect on whether your position (on policy making or taking) applies to all municipal issues, or is limited to the issue you have focused on, and why. From your perspective of municipalities as policy makers or policy takers, and your research on the issue, identify and discuss at least three related policy challenges or opportunities in the municipal policy process.
- **Municipalities and the Constitution** - “Local governments must get beyond the limiting mindset that they are but constitutional orphans who must constantly plead for better treatment from the provincial (and federal) government. They need to recognize their growing importance, seek out alliances within the public and private sector, and pursue a collaborative approach to the issues and challenges that they face.” (Tindal, C.R., Tindal, S.N., Stewart, K. & Smith, P.J. (2013). *Local government in Canada*, 8th ed., Toronto: Nelson Education., p. 185)

Others argue that municipalities should advocate for recognition in the Constitution as an order of government and negotiate formal relations with the provincial and federal governments.

In your opinion, and based on your research, what is the best approach to intergovernmental relations for municipalities - the current approach, a collaborative approach, constitutional recognition, or another approach? Why?

- **Representation and Size of Council** - There has been a lot of discussion about the size of municipal councils, initiated by the Premier of Ontario's decision to reduce the size of Toronto City Council from 47 members to 25 members in 2018. The size of a municipal council has significant implications for effective and democratic representation and for decision-making structures and processes in the municipality. Is there a right size? What is the right size? Why? What are the factors that need to be considered in determining levels of effective representation for municipalities? (**Note:** this is not a discussion of the size of the City of Toronto Council)
- **Representation and Elections** - Local government is described as the level of government closest to the people yet fewer and fewer people vote in municipal elections. Municipal elections were held in Ontario, British Columbia, PEI, and Manitoba in the fall of 2022 and while there were some examples of high municipal voter turnout, most municipal elections experienced low or declining turnout. What is the problem? What are the options and what do you recommend needs to be done to reverse this troubling trend in municipal voter turnout before we go to the polls again in October 2026?
- **Community Connection and Engagement** – Section 224 of the [Municipal Act, 2001](#) describes the role of municipal councils “(a) to represent the public and to consider the well-being and interests of the municipality”. Municipalities use many different vehicles and initiatives to consider the well-being and interests of local residents and communities. Look at one municipality and conduct research into its efforts to engage and connect with communities and residents. What does research say about good and effective practices? Based on your assessment, are community interests effectively represented and understood at the municipal level? What is working well and what could be improved and how?
- **Other Topic** - Are you interested in a different topic for the assignment? Do you want to focus on a municipal service issue? Please contact the Instructor to discuss whether your topic would be acceptable for the assignment.

This assignment requires that you:

- conduct some research on a chosen topic
- describe the issue and explain why it is important to municipalities
- develop your position concerning the chosen issue and develop a written body of evidence from course and non-course sources that supports your position. This might include a discussion of options or an analysis of a situation.

This assignment is to be in formal essay format, between 1,800 -2,400 words or 6 - 8 pages, double spaced, 11 - 12 size font. This limit will force you to be well organized and clear in your paper. Please properly cite and reference all sources. You are encouraged to use APA referencing.

You are expected to use the course materials and to conduct additional research on your topic. You must connect your discussion and analysis to at least **5 course sources** (readings, content, discussions) In addition, you must demonstrate connection to at least **3 non-course sources** from academic or peer reviewed books and/or journals. You are welcome to use grey media and website material in addition to these required sources.

You must take a position in this paper - it is not sufficient to describe a situation or problem. You must use the research that you have gathered from course and non-course (academic and non-academic sources) to support your analysis and reflection.

Advice and Instructions

You are encouraged to structure your essay as follows:

- Introduction - to the topic and to the issue or question that you are writing about. Why is it important? What is your thesis or position, what will you argue or try to prove in the paper?
- Body of the Essay
 - Background - to the issue/topic
 - Main Points/Paragraphs - this is the evidence that you have found through your research to support your position or opinion, describes options, etc. Organize the evidence into a number of clear and strong points. Describe the evidence, explain why it is relevant to your issue and why it supports the position you are taking. You may also choose to highlight some of the criticisms of your position and offer a counter argument against those criticisms.
- Conclusion - summarize the issue, summarize the main evidence provided to support your position, reflect on the issue or question, identify the implications of your position, etc. Conclude the paper.

This assignment is worth 30% of your final course grade. It will be graded based on the following breakdown:

10 Marks	Introduction and description of the issue Clear statement of the issue you are addressing in the paper Discussion of why the issue is important to the municipality or local government in general - include evidence
14 marks	Clear presentation of your position on the issue – justify/defend your position based on supporting evidence and research Justification – convincing, complete, range (course and non-course sources), different types of evidence/source May include options/alternatives considered, may include references to other jurisdictions or experiences Conclusions and summary of key points, issues, positions and any additional reflections on the topic
6 marks	Clearly communicated and organized; bibliography/references/citations; connection to course materials (discussions, readings, content, etc.), connection to non-course research or peer reviewed sources appropriate to subject/issue.

Due: End of Week 10, Friday 11:59 pm.